FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

GROWING PAINS & INJURIES

Know when to rest, when to play and when to get it checked

THE QUICK VERSION

> Growing bodies go through big changes, and growth spurts can bring aches, clumsiness and a few niggles. Most of these settle with rest, but some need attention. Knowing the difference helps you protect your child without wrapping them in cotton wool.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

During a growth spurt, bones grow faster than muscles and tendons can keep up. That's why many young players get sore heels, knees or hips, or suddenly feel less coordinated for a while. Pain that keeps coming back, gets worse, or changes how your child runs should always be checked by a physio or GP.

IS IT A NIGGLE, OR TIME TO GET IT CHECKED?

USUALLY OKAY TO MONITOR

- ✓ Mild soreness the day after a big session
- ✓ Aches that ease with rest
- ✓ Muscle tightness that improves with gentle movement
- ✓ Feeling a bit clumsy during a growth spurt

GET IT CHECKED

- × Pain that keeps returning or gets worse
- × Limping or changing how they run
- × Swelling, bruising or a joint that gives way
- × Pain at night or at rest
- × Any knock to the head

Head knocks: if in doubt, sit them out

If your child has a knock to the head and shows any signs of concussion (headache, dizziness, confusion, vomiting or just "not right"), they must stop playing and see a doctor. Follow a proper return-to-play plan before they train again.

TRY THIS

1. **Ask, don't assume**
   "Does anything hurt?" Many kids hide pain so they don't miss games.
2. **Rest is a tool**
   A few days off now can prevent weeks off later.
3. **Warm up properly**
   Encourage a full warm-up before every session and game.
4. **Watch the load during growth spurts**
   Talk to the coach about easing the workload if your child is growing quickly.
5. **See a physio for repeat niggles**
   A physio can find the cause and give simple exercises to fix it.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"Does anything hurt? Let's check it."	~~"Toughen up, it's nothing."~~
"Resting a few days now saves weeks later."	~~"You can't miss the game, play through it."~~
"If you hit your head, you sit out."	~~"You look fine, get back on."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My child feels safe telling me when something hurts
- [ ] I know the signs of concussion
- [ ] We get repeat niggles checked by a professional
- [ ] I talk to the coach when my child is growing fast

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

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Playing through pain isn't brave. Telling someone it hurts is. Protecting a young body now is what gives a player a long career later.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM